Sub-Themes & Interactive Elements

Team: Biscuit

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Museum of Theft explores how the meaning of “theft” changes depending on what is taken, who takes it, who is called a thief, and who has the authority to define and narrate the act. The exhibition is thematically progressive rather than chronological. Each section can be understood independently, but together the sections progressively complicate the visitor's initial definition of theft. This follows the original proposal's aim of presenting a progression rather than unrelated examples.

A brief sequence of the museum’s subthemes are as follows:

- **Entry: What is theft?**
- **Section I: Who is the thief?**
- **Section II: What can be taken?**
- **Section III: Who names the act and who owns the story?**
- **Exit: Has your definition changed?**

Section 1: Who is the thief?

This section forms the opening act for the museum and presents three cases to the viewer, relaxing the rigidness around the general idea of “theft” they’ve developed through experiences in their lives. It begins with a general case of pickpocketing, and then moves onto the folklore of Robin Hood, where the intention is for the viewer to see how societal perception changes with intent and perpetrators. The section finally closes with the Benin Bronzes, where responsibility for the taking becomes distributed across soldiers, officers, dealers and museums, complicating the question of who exactly should be called the thief.

1. Ordinary theft

We start out with a regular **pickpocketing** case one would find on the streets of a busy city, perhaps a stolen wallet.

The victim and the thief both seek the value of the object and it is crystal clear who stole what from whom. A law has been broken and its consequences shall follow.

Exhibit: a wallet, a pocket watch, a phone. Beside it a reproduced court record or wanted notice from the actual case.

In the second half of the nineteenth century, department stores arrived in the streets all over Europe. The concept of shoplifting followed, however, the thieves in question were middle-class women (the store's most valued customers), who were taking things they could have easily afforded. This compulsion was medically termed Kleptomania, and women of this class were often not charged with the crime, instead, matters were handled privately and they were often let go. A working-class woman caught at the same counter, with the same object in her pocket, had no access to any of this. She was caught as a thief and prosecuted as one.

The labelling of a person as a "thief" is more nuanced than just the act of the taking, society plays a significant role in the making of the persona.

Exhibit: A kleptomania medical diagnosis page, two records of a "stolen item" incident and the different verdicts recorded, possibly footage and interiors of the time to support the claims.

2. The outlaw (Robin Hood)

Robin Hood becomes an outlaw after a conflict with local authorities in his town and a series of events leads him to build a loyal band of outlaws called the Merry Men. The group fights against tyranny, heavy taxes and corrupt officials by robbing wealthy travelers and redistributing the wealth to the poor. The ballads from the sixteenth century and onwards celebrate him for it. People use the phrase "robbing the rich to give to the poor," approvingly without hesitating in his context.

Robin Hood is essentially identical to a mere pickpocketer on the street in terms of the legality of his acts, what differs is the intent and the end goal, which changes his perception in society. Because the victim was rich and the proceeds went to the poor, the culture filed it under justice rather than crime.

Exhibit: Ballad texts, illustrations across the centuries (of the man) and film posters.

3. The Benin Bronzes

In 1897, a British punitive expedition captured Benin City, burned the royal palace and removed thousands of brass plaques, ivories and commemorative heads. Many were auctioned in London to defray the cost of the expedition itself. Others were passed on to Western museums through purchases, donations and transfers over the following decades. The objects were not currency or raw material, they were the palace's own record of its dynasty, kept in place as an archive rather than as decoration.

It is not clear who the thief is, in this scenario. The soldier who carried a plaque out of the burning palace was following orders. The officers were executing an expedition authorised in London. The auction that sold the objects was held to recover its costs. The dealer bought legally, the museum bought legally from the dealer, and the curator who catalogued it in 1950 took nothing from anyone. In 2022 the Smithsonian transferred ownership of 29 objects

to Nigeria, but a museum that gives something back held it for a century, built its reputation partly on it, and is now praised for returning it. Does that make it less of a thief, or only a former one?

Exhibit: One reproduction or large image of a single plaque placed centrally, news articles and media pages covering the transfer and resulting outrage.

Section 2: What can be taken?

This section expands the visitor's idea of what the “thing” being taken can be. Rather than focusing only on physical possessions, the cases examine how reproducible resources, biological samples and publicly available images can be copied, reused, transformed or made newly valuable without the original necessarily disappearing. Together, they ask whether something can be “taken” when the original remains, and whether possessing or accessing something also gives permission to use everything that can later be produced from it.

1. Rubber

In 1876, Henry Wickham transported roughly 70,000 Pará rubber seeds from the Brazilian Amazon to Britain, from where they were later propagated through the British imperial network in Asia. Brazil did not lose its rubber trees, the export was not prohibited by Brazilian law at the time, and Asian production only overtook Brazil decades later. Yet as the economic consequences of the transfer became visible, the way the event was remembered changed. British accounts celebrated it as botanical introduction and imperial achievement, while later Brazilian accounts increasingly described Wickham as a thief and the episode as theft or biopiracy. The case therefore asks whether something can be stolen even when the original remains, and whether an act can come to be understood as theft only after its consequences become clear.

Exhibit: A rubber seed or replica or an image of the rubber tree and latex, a map tracing Brazil → Kew → Ceylon/Southeast Asia; an excerpt from the 1877 British/Kew account presenting the transfer as successful botanical introduction; and a later Brazilian source, such as Pesquisa FAPESP or Museu Goeldi, framing the episode through theft/biopiracy.

2. Havasupai Blood Samples

Beginning in 1990, members of the Havasupai Tribe provided blood for research centred on diabetes. The complication arose when the samples were subsequently used for other research, including schizophrenia, population genetics and migration/ancestry. The central question is therefore not simply whether the blood was “stolen”, it was voluntarily given, but how far the original permission extended once the sample could produce new kinds of information. For the Havasupai participants, the issue was not simply that their blood had been reused, but that material given within a project they understood primarily as diabetes research was later used for purposes they said they had not knowingly agreed to. This raised a larger question for the exhibition: can losing control over uses and information that one did not knowingly authorize constitute a form of theft, even when the original sample was voluntarily given? In the 2010 settlement, remaining samples and research materials

were returned and further research using the samples was stopped, but information and publications already produced could not simply be returned.

Exhibits: An empty blood-collection tube as the main physical object, a simple map/image of Supai, a visual showing *BLOOD → DNA → DATA → ANCESTRY*, and a short display comparing what the community understood the research to be with the different forms of consent documented. And a final settlement panel which shows the return of the samples, research materials and the end of further research using the samples.

3. Clearview AI

Clearview AI collected photographs that were publicly available on the internet and used them to build a facial-recognition search engine. The photographs themselves remained where they had originally been posted. Clearview instead analysed the faces in them, converted them into numerical biometric identifiers, and indexed them against billions of other images. A user could then submit a new photograph of an unknown person and receive matching photographs and links to webpages where that face had previously appeared. Privacy regulators in Canada treated the creation and use of this biometric information as distinct from merely collecting the original photographs, and found that people had not reasonably expected their public images to be used for facial identification at this scale. Thus, a photograph that once simply made a person visible online could now also make that person searchable across otherwise separate contexts.

Exhibits: A staged social-media-style photograph; a simple visual showing **POSTED ONLINE → COLLECTED → FACE DATA → SEARCHABLE**; and a side-by-side panel showing **“I posted this publicly”** versus **“I agreed to this use.”** The aim is to make visitors see how something they willingly put online can acquire a new use they did not specifically intend. Several staged photographs of the same consenting volunteer in different settings, such as a college event, café and street scene; a smartphone or laptop displaying a mocked-up Clearview-style search in which one photograph leads to the others; an enlarged visual representation of the numerical facial vector generated from a face; a reproduced excerpt from the Canadian privacy regulator explaining that biometric information was separately created from the original photograph; and a small set of screenshots/headlines showing the scale and regulatory response to Clearview.

Section 3: Who Names the Act and Who Owns the Story?

As visitors progress through the first two sections of the museum, they are introduced to the grayness and subjectivity of theft: seeing how the label of "thief" shifts based on class, and how the "items" stolen have evolved from physical money to human rights and digital data. This final section, "Who Names the Act and Who Owns the Story?", confronts the ultimate power dynamic in the history of theft: the power to write the official record i.e. the theft of the narrative.

One of the most critical features of public history is grappling with conflicting versions of the past. When an act of taking occurs, the story of that act is usually written by whoever holds the most power. If history is written by the victors, the history of theft is written by those who

control the courts, the archives, and the museum placards. They use administrative language to sanitise extraction, turning "looting" into "archaeological preservation", or "dispossession" into "eminent domain", while simultaneously criminalising the survival tactics of the marginalised.

Through this section, we want to prompt visitors to realise that the archive itself is a battleground. We aim to show that the definition of a historical event changes completely depending on whose perspective is preserved. By examining conflicting narratives, visitors are challenged to ask: When the law itself is written by the people doing the taking, how do the victims reclaim their story?

To highlight this friction, this section will function as a “room of dual narratives”. We will present specific historical case studies where the "official" institutional record is placed directly alongside the "counter-narrative" of the community. By juxtaposing state documents against counter-archives, we will drive the visitor to play the role of the historian. They will have to navigate these conflicting accounts and decide for themselves which version of the story holds the truth and whether it is possible to determine that at all or not.

We can structure each case study as a **"Dual Narrative Display"**, where we split the physical exhibit space in half (Side A vs. Side B) to press the visitor to confront the conflicting stories.

1. The Dawes General Allotment Act (1887)

The core conflict here is that of institutional "assimilation" versus the systematic theft of sovereign tribal territory. Under the Dawes Act of 1887, the US government forcibly broke up communally held Indigenous reservations into individual private family plots, officially classifying over 90 million unallocated acres as "surplus land." Through this administrative vocabulary, government reports and school textbooks reframed the mass confiscation of native territory as "peaceful westward expansion" and cast white homesteaders as industrious "pioneers." On the contrary, Native American nations experienced this not as benevolent reform, but as the calculated destruction of their communal way of life and the legalized theft of two-thirds of their treaty-guaranteed land base. By inventing the neutral bureaucratic category of "surplus," the state named the act, laundered the theft into law, and wrote itself into historical memory as a civilizer rather than a plunderer.

Exhibit: A reproduction of an authentic 1911 Department of the Interior promotional poster advertising *"INDIAN LAND FOR SALE: Get a Home of Your Own, 350,000 Acres Opened to Settlement,"* pinned right next to an archival petition by tribal delegates protesting allotment as a violation of sacred treaties, paired with a map illustrating the loss of 90 million acres of reservation land.

2. The Hasdeo Arand Forest (Present Day)

The core conflict here is that of corporate "development" versus Indigenous land theft. The clearing of the Hasdeo Arand forest in Chhattisgarh is framed in government clearances and corporate PR as "national energy security," "development," and "job creation." Under this vocabulary, extracting coal is a noble, legal necessity for the nation. On the contrary, the

local Adivasi (Indigenous) communities argue that the forest is their ancestral home, livelihood, and sacred space. Because mining proceeds despite the rejection of the local Gram Sabhas (village councils), the community defines this not as development, but as the illegal theft of their land, resources, and ecological future.

Exhibit: A glossy corporate sustainability brochure about "powering India" pinned right next to a printed copy of a signed Gram Sabha resolution refusing consent, or a photograph of Adivasi women hugging trees to stop the bulldozers.

Interactive Elements

We intend to capture the flow of thought of the viewer throughout the museum in two major ways. Firstly, two polls shall be filled by the visitor: one at the beginning and the other at the end. The questionnaire will be short and interactive, and consist of the same questions (primarily). The target of this element is to judge the shift in the opinion of the general crowd appearing through the exit gates.

A second interactive element will be present at each story-point and will collect on-prem opinions on the case it displays: whether the visitor believes the case is a clear theft, genuinely not a theft or unsure of their thoughts. The activity will be conducted in the form of placing notes on a board, or other forms of visual record-keeping. This helps the visitor to ponder for longer upon the themes and their thoughts on the same.